MODULE 52 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Mechanics and Strategy

Seventy-five questions, three hours, five domains and a passing score of 720. How the exam is scored, how to spend the time, and how to read a long stem.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All five MODULE 52 of 52

admin@sthithapragna.com

The format, precisely

- **75 questions in 180 minutes.** 65 are scored; 10 are unscored and not identified.
- **Multiple choice:** one correct answer. **Multiple response:** two or more correct out of five or more.
- **Multiple response needs every correct option.** There is no partial credit.
- **Unanswered scores as incorrect**, and guessing carries no penalty.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> About one question in seven does not count, and you cannot tell which. Treat every one as real.

How it is scored

- **Scaled from 100 to 1,000, with 720 to pass.** C02 needed 750.
- **Compensatory:** you pass on the total, not domain by domain.
- A weak domain can be carried by strong ones, but not a weak heavy one.
- **720 is not 72%.** Scaling adjusts for form difficulty, so aim well clear.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The section table on your score report is diagnostic. Only the total decides the result.

Where the questions come from

DOMAIN	WEIGHT	ABOUT, OF 65 SCORED
1 Architecture built for the cloud	25%	16
2 Security, compliance, governance	25%	16
3 Cost-optimized architecture	15%	10
4 Resilience, migration, continuity	15%	10
5 Operational excellence, automation	20%	13

ON THE EXAM

Half the scored questions come from Domains 1 and 2. Prioritise revision by weight times weakness.

The time budget

- **2.4 minutes per question** on average; some take forty seconds, some five minutes.
- **Checkpoints:** question 25 by minute 60, question 50 by minute 120.
- **The common failure** is six minutes on one question, then rushing the last twenty.
- **Flag and move at three minutes.** Come back with fresh eyes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Two checkpoints catch drift early. You cannot feel elapsed time reliably under pressure.

Reading a long stem

- **Read the final question first**, then the scenario.
- **Find the constraint sentence**: cost, downtime, deadline, who may change what.
- **Note the superlative:** MOST cost-effective, LEAST operational overhead.
- **Planted details eliminate options.** New to AWS, existing framework, no labels: none is background.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Most stems contain one sentence that removes two options. Find it before weighing all four.

C03 clues worth knowing

- **New account or new to AWS** tests closed-to-new-customers services.
- **Changing facts, citations** point to RAG, not customisation.
- **Created by hand, any tool** point past Hooks to SCPs or Config.
- **Never, guarantee** demand preventive controls, not detective ones.
- Training or fine-tuning as the answer to a knowledge problem is usually a distractor.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Training and fine-tuning models are listed as out of scope for the candidate.

The day itself

- **Breaks are unscheduled and the clock keeps running.** Decide in advance.
- Online proctoring needs a quiet room and a clear desk; a test centre needs ID.
- **Retakes** require a 14-day wait, so leave room before any deadline.
- Fatigue is the real adversary at three hours. Sleep beats a final evening of revision.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Check the AWS certification page before booking. These details were recorded in November 2026.

> At the 100-minute mark you have completed 38 questions, and six are flagged. The scenarios are long but not conceptually hard.
>
> There are 80 minutes and 37 questions left.

What should you do?

A Speed up to about two minutes per remaining question, and leave the six flagged questions until the end

B Go back and resolve the six flagged questions now

C Keep the current pace and accept leaving some unanswered

D Skip ahead and answer only the easiest remaining questions

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

A Speed up, defer flags

37 in about 74 minutes leaves time for the flags.

B Flags now

Spends scarce time before every question is seen.

C Same pace

Blank answers score zero.

D Easiest only

Leaves points on the table.

THE SIGNAL

Behind the checkpoint: speed up, see every question, return to flags last.

> A question says Select TWO. You are confident about one option and cannot decide between two others. You have spent two and a half minutes.
>
> Multiple response needs every correct option for credit.

What should you do?

A. Select only the option you are sure of

B. Spend another three minutes working it out

C. Select your confident option plus the more likely of the other two, flag it, and move on

D. Leave it blank and return at the end

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

A One selection

Certain to score zero.

B Three more minutes

Breaks the time budget for a coin flip.

C Best guess, flag, move

A fair chance now, and a second look later.

D Blank

Zero if time runs out.

THE SIGNAL

No partial credit: always select the full number asked for.

> Two options remain. One adds a CloudFormation Guard Hook; the other adds an AWS Config rule with automatic remediation. You have re-read both options twice.
>
> You have not re-read the scenario.

What should you do?

A Choose the Hook, since preventing is better than fixing

B Choose the Config rule, since it covers more

C Guess and move on immediately

D Re-read the requirement for how resources are created, such as the console or the CLI, and when the check must happen

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

A Always the Hook

Misses anything made outside CloudFormation.

B Always Config

Fails a before-provisioning requirement.

C Guess

The deciding words are already on screen.

D Re-read the requirement

The pair is settled by how and when.

THE SIGNAL

Stuck between a pair: the divider is in the requirement, not in the options.

> With three minutes left, four flagged questions are unanswered. All are long, and reading one properly would take most of the time.
>
> There is no penalty for guessing.

What should you do?

A Answer all four with quick best guesses, then reconsider one if time remains

B Read one carefully and leave three blank

C Read two quickly and answer only those

D Leave them blank, since wrong answers count against you

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

A **Guess all four first**
Each guess has a chance; blanks have none.

B **One careful answer**
Three certain zeros.

C **Two quick answers**
Two certain zeros.

D **Leave blank**
Wrong answers are not penalised.

THE SIGNAL

Final minutes: fill every blank first, then improve answers.

> A practice exam returns these domain scores: Domain 1 72%, Domain 2 58%, Domain 3 60%, Domain 4 75%, Domain 5 70%.
>
> The real exam is in ten days.

Where should most of the remaining revision go?

A Spread evenly across all five domains

B Domain 3, since it is close to the weakest

C Domain 2, since it is the weakest and carries 25% of the exam

D More full practice exams until the score rises

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Where should most of the remaining revision go?

A Even spread

Wastes time on strong domains.

B Domain 3

Similar gap, but only 15% of questions.

C Domain 2

Largest gap times largest weight.

D More practice exams

Measures the gap without closing it.

THE SIGNAL

Revise by weight times weakness: Domain 2 here, Domain 3 second.

> An architect earned the SAP-C02 certification in March 2025. It is now November 2026, and C02 is no longer offered.
>
> She asks whether her certification has lapsed and what she must do to keep it.

What is the correct advice?

A. It lapsed when C02 retired; she must sit C03 immediately

B. It stays valid until its three-year expiry; she recertifies by passing the current version, C03, before then

C. It converts automatically to a C03 certification

D. She must sit C02 again before it expires

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the correct advice?

A Lapsed

Retiring an exam does not cancel certifications.

B Valid, recertify on C03

Three years from passing; recertify on the current exam.

C Converts

No automatic conversion.

D Sit C02 again

C02 is no longer offered.

THE SIGNAL

The credential is Solutions Architect Professional. The exam version only changes how you earn it.

What to carry out of this module

- **Never leave a question blank**, and always select the full number asked for.
- **Checkpoints:** question 25 by minute 60, question 50 by minute 120.
- **Question first, then stem**; find the constraint and the superlative.
- **Revise by weight times weakness**; 720 passes on the total.
- Thank you for taking the course, and good luck.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Practice exams follow: five domain papers and a full 75-question mock.